

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1999-05-04

To an individual believer

1 dear b ahá'í f riend,

2 1998 requesting clarification of the policies governing access to sources at the bahá'í
world center and regarding publication of primary source mate-

3 rial available to people through other avenues. i t welcomes the opportunity

4 to provide further information on these issues and has instructed us to send you the
following reply.

5 your questions have to be considered in the context of the range of the

6 important functions of the head of the cause is to guide the faithful to the

7 tasks which need to be performed at each stage in its progress. it must allo-

8 cate the resources of the faith and point out those areas on which attention

9 should be focused. Naturally, each individual tends to see the importance

10 of his or her special interests or to focus on needs which are immediately

11 apparent. All these have their own validity, but it is the universal house of

12 justice which sees the whole picture and can guide the process. The friends

13 must have faith in this, otherwise their efforts will be dissipated and even

14 mutually conflicting.

15 The question of providing access to primary source materials is but one

16 of the matters which must occupy the attention and consume the resources

17 of the cause. The written material of this dispensation is incomparably

18 rich and varied, and we now stand only a century and a half from the day on which
the báb announced h is mission to m ullá þusayn in Shíráz.

19 Access to source documents relating to the bahá'í faith which are held in

20 libraries in different parts of the world, or are in the hands of individuals, is open to
anyone who wishes to consult them, dependent only on the permis-sion of the institution or
individual in whose possession the documents are 302.1

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304 675held. A major service which a number of bahá'í scholars have rendered to
305 the faith is in tracing such deposits and, where possible, obtaining archival
306 quality photocopies for the world center Archives and library.

307 As for source documents at the world center itself: these are held by the
308 universal house of justice in trust for the entire bahá'í world and ultimately
309 for the whole of humankind, of both present and future generations. There
310 is tremendous work to be accomplished in sorting, identifying and catalog-

311 ing such documents so that they can be effectively studied without either damaging
them or losing vital information by disturbing their interrelation-ships. As far as the urgent
needs of the faith are concerned, the primary

312 work in this respect must be devoted to the Sacred Texts rather than to documents of
historical interest, although the latter are by no means ig-nored. it would be irresponsible for
the house of justice, without itself first

313 being fully informed of what is in the Archives, to consider opening them to
individual scholars for the pursuit of purely personal interests.

314 far from allowing anyone to tamper with the historical records, the uni-
315 versal house of justice has the obligation to preserve the integrity, not only
316 of the Sacred Texts, but of all the historical documents in its possession. it

317 has, moreover, a responsibility for arranging their publication for the schol-arly
world in a coherent manner that will not give a misleading impression of events as a result of
the mere choice of the items and the order in which

318 they are made public. undoubtedly, in due course, it will be possible to
319 publish editions of historical documents in facsimile accompanied, in the
320 case of each document, by a printed transcription, and supplemented by
321 necessary commentaries and notes. it is with such thoughts in mind that the
322 house of justice feels that a certain discipline is required of those individual
323 believers who decide, for their own purposes, to publish or translate docu-
324 ments which they have at hand.

This entire process is made the more delicate by past experience with

325 those who, pursuing unacknowledged agendas of their own, have wished to publish
certain documents for ulterior motives, or with others who have lacked the good sense and
breadth of vision to act responsibly.

326 you refer to the principle of the unfettered search after truth. This is
327 certainly upheld, but it cannot imply that the institutions of the faith have
328 a duty to make available to each inquirer every piece of information he or
329 she requests. we are faced here, not with wisdom prevailing over the search
330 for truth, but with a process of organic growth, both in the world and, com-

mensurate with it, at the world center of the faith.302.5

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303 meS Sa g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

304 on your behalf in the holy Shrines for the reinforcement of your devoted

305 endeavors to advance the interests of the cause of b ahá'u'lláh.

306 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

Department of the secretariat

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Increased Need for Contributions

to the Bahá'í International Fund

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]